REIMAGINING UBUNTU IN A CONNECTED WORLD

South Africa faces a pivotal moment: bridging the tech divide with inclusive, future-focused solutions

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South Africa's G20 presidency comes at a time of intersecting global crises – climate change, inequality, geopolitical instability and rapid technological transformation.

With the theme "Solidarity, Equality, Sustainability" and the philosophy of Ubuntu at its core, the country has the opportunity to shape a digital future that's inclusive, ethical, and locally grounded.

"Countries that attempt to prosper alone amid widespread poverty and underdevelopment contradict the essence of Ubuntu and our collective humanity," reads the G20 presidency's official message.

Global lessons

The digital divide is no longer just about who's online – but who can meaningfully participate in the digital economy.

Dr Jonathan Shock, associate professor at UCT's Department of Mathematics and Applied Mathematics, highlights models from around the world that offer insight. Estonia's secure national platforms, Singapore's industry-academia training programmes, and India's rapid rollout of digital IDs have driven inclusive economic growth.

"But while we can learn from others, South Africa must build for its own reality," says Shock. "We need to invest in local infrastructure, local talent, and our own digital sovereignty."

AI and digital tools, he says, offer enormous entrepreneurial potential – but without access to training, those possibilities will remain out of reach for many.

Measuring real access

Rowen Pillai, CEO of LeanTechnovations, argues that quality of access matters more than simple connectivity.

"Across the G20, even rural areas in developed countries struggle with speed and reliability. In emerging economies like ours, the barrier is affordability," he explains.

"We need to move from counting towers to measuring outcomes – latency, speed, safety, and cost – at a district level."

Pillai advocates for modernised Universal Service Funds, outcome-based tenders, and smarter infrastructure planning to ensure that connectivity is meaningful and scalable.

A dual-track future

To build resilience, Pillai suggests a two-pronged strategy: align with global governance standards like the EU AI Act and the NIST AI Risk Framework, while simultaneously building local capabilities.

This includes investing in green data centres, affordable compute, and practical AI skills in key sectors like health, mining, and agriculture.

He also stresses transparency in power and water use, ensuring that AI-era infrastructure doesn't deepen other resource divides.

A digital economy

For South Africa, this moment is not just about catching up – but about leading differently. A digital economy anchored in Ubuntu means putting people first, protecting their data, and expanding opportunity.

As the country steps onto the global stage, the challenge – and opportunity – is clear: to harness global momentum while building a connected, equitable digital future that reflects who we are.